In February 2024, Colonel Anuj Antal, the administrative commandant of the army cantonment in the border town of Ferozepur, Punjab, wrote to then governor Banwarilal Purohit, seeking a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) enquiry and the registration of an FIR against district revenue officials for forging records pertaining to 15 acres of land belonging to the military. His allegation: that the piece of land outside the cantonment known as Jahaz Ground—once an emergency airfield for the Indian Air Force (IAF) used as camouflaging ground for weaponry during the 1962, 1965 and 1971 wars—had been sold off to private individuals, compromising security near the India-Pakistan border. This is not an isolated incident, across India, land owned by the armed forces—spread across prime locations and worth crores of rupees—has been grabbed by real estate mafias with the alleged involvement of local officials, military personnel and bureaucrats within the ministry of defence (MoD). Indeed, the situation is dire: according to the Centre, an estimated 10,354 acres of defence land is being illegally encroached upon or sold off in fraudulent deals.

The armed forces own 17.31 lakh acres of land across India. Among the three services, the army owns the largest share of 13.79 lakh acres—around 80 per cent. Two lakh acres of defence land is inside 61 cantonments. Outside the cantonments, 15.3 lakh acres are used as army and IAF stations, naval bases, DRDO (Defence Research and Development Organisation) labs, firing ranges and camping grounds.

Crucially, 45,906 acres of land under the three services and MoD organisations is currently lying vacant for a number of reasons—reserved for future use, placed under the management of the central or state governments and leased out to private individuals. Before independence, and for decades thereafter, parcels of land belonging to the armed forces lay on the outskirts of towns and cities. But with growing urbanisation, they are now prime real estate with skyrocketing prices. It is these vacant plots of land that are mostly targeted for illegal encroachment and outright loot by land sharks in connivance with corrupt officials. Systemic corruption, to be sure, is to be blamed, but its real enablers are the apathy of the armed forces vis-à-vis such land, an uneasy division of labour between the military and the MoD and a total lack of vigilance on the stakeholders' part.

That the issue of stealing military land is a serious concern was highlighted in August when, in answer to a question, the MoD informed Parliament that with 1,779 acres, Uttar Pradesh tops the list among states with the most encroached defence land, followed by Madhya Pradesh (1,758 acres), Maharashtra (1,031 acres), West Bengal (816 acres) and Haryana (780 acres). Even the national capital makes the list, with 147.6 acres of encroachments in Delhi.



"WE MUST ADMIT WE DO NOT HAVE A STRONG MECHANISM TO CHECK INCREASED ENCROACHMENT ON VACANT DEFENCE LAND"

LT GEN. ARVIND SHARMA
Former Additional Director of Land, Works, and Environment

Of course, with past instances like the Adarsh housing scandal, Sukna land scam and the Pune land case which rocked the nation, the Ferozepur case is part of a larger pattern. But it does highlight an alarming trend where land related to maintaining military readiness is repeatedly compromised, endangering critical infrastructure and raising questions about the integrity of the systems meant to protect the nation's assets. In recent years, the military has faced infrastructure bottlenecks due to limited land availability for expanding bases, training centres and storage depots that are exacerbated by these scams. Moreover, defence land is often located in strategic locations near borders, making its illegal occupation a graver threat to national security as it could affect future operational requirements.

Lt Gen. Arvind Sharma (retd), former additional director of land, works and environment, the office that handles army land, says such encroachment is an organised business, where politicians and the bureaucracy are hand in glove. "I must admit that we do not have a strong mechanism to check this. By the time we detect an encroachment in a portion of our land, it has